

Question:

A mental health volunteer is interviewing locals as part of a community outreach program. A 46-year-old man discloses that he has felt sad for as long as he can remember. He feels as though his life is cursed and if something terrible can happen to him, it usually will. He has difficulty making decisions and feels hopeless. He also feels that he has had worsening suicidal ideations, guilt from past problems, energy, and concentration over the past 2 weeks. He is otherwise getting enough sleep and able to hold a job. Which of the following statement best describes this patient's condition?

Answer Choices:

- A. The patient is at risk for double depression.
- B. The patient may have symptoms of mania or psychosis.
- C. The patient is likely to show anhedonia.
- D. The patient likely has paranoid personality disorder.

Reasoning + Answer:

<think> The patient is describing symptoms of persistent sadness, hopelessness, difficulty making decisions, and worsening suicidal ideations over the past 2 weeks. These symptoms are characteristic of depression, specifically persistent depressive disorder (dysthymia) or a major depressive episode. The patient's belief that if something terrible can happen to him, it usually will, is also known as "hitler's law" or "poison pill effect," which is a common thought pattern in individuals with depression. The patient's symptoms do not suggest symptoms of mania or psychosis, such as grandiosity, impulsivity, or disorganized thinking, which are more characteristic of bipolar disorder. Anhedonia, or the loss of pleasure in activities, is a common symptom of depression, but it is not the best description of the patient's condition based on the information provided. Paranoid personality disorder is a personality disorder characterized by a pervasive distrust and suspicion of others, which is not described in the patient's symptoms. The patient's symptoms are more consistent with a depressive disorder. The patient's description of worsening symptoms over the past 2 weeks may indicate a possibility of double depression, which is a term used to describe the occurrence of major depressive episodes superimposed on a chronic depressive disorder (dysthymia). </think> <answer> A. The patient is at risk for double depression. </answer>